some sense of it. Their difficulty lies in the fact that very few seals carry more than four or five of these ‘characters’ and none more than twenty-four, which is in marked contrast to the extensively inscribed cuneiform tablets of Mesopotamia, for example. This suggests that this Harappan ‘script’ is not a written language at all but more in the nature of symbols identifying goods, amounts, places, ownership and so on. In recent years much-publicised claims have been made that purport to prove links with either the Dravidian or Sanskrit language families, but the fact is that despite all the industry of such acknowledged experts as the indefatigable Tamil scholar Dr Iravatham Mahadevan (whose pioneering work on the identification and deciphering of Tamil-Brahmi is described in a later chapter) and the Finnish scholar Asko Parpola, the deciphering of the Harappan ‘script’ is still a work in progress.

What offer a far more profitable line of enquiry are the images on the seals, of which the most famous is Seal 420, uncovered in 1928 from Mohenjo-Daro (see illustration on page 49). It shows a figure seated on a platform, facing forward in a yoga-like *padmasana* or ‘lotus-position’ posture. His arms are covered in bangles and he wears an elaborate headdress in the form of a pair of curved horns with a plant-like object in the centre. His head is ill-defined – not surprising, when you consider that the seal measures barely one inch (2.7 centimetres) square and is damaged – but with some squinting and a little imagination it can be seen as three faces, one facing forward and two in profile. Sir John Marshall had no hesitation in calling this horned man a ‘proto-Siva’, or early form of Lord Shiva. ‘In the first place,’ he wrote, ‘the figure has three faces and that Siva was portrayed with three as well as with more usual five faces, there are abundant examples to prove. Secondly, the head is crowned with the horns of a bull and the *trisula* [trident] are characteristic emblems of Siva. Thirdly, the figure is in a typical yoga attitude, and Siva was, and still is, regarded as